DRUGS · EAR PREPARATIONS

Cerumenolytics

Cerumenolytics soften ear wax so that it comes out on its own or can be removed by irrigation or microsuction. Water, saline and oils work about as well as proprietary products. They are a first step for impacted wax causing hearing loss, discomfort or obstruction of the view, and they are used for 3 to 5 days before irrigation.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The preparations on one page.

1.1 Summary

CERUMENOLYTICS

	SUMMARY
Preparations	Olive oil; sodium bicarbonate 5% drops; urea hydrogen peroxide; docusate; almond and arachis (peanut) oil products; water and saline
How they work	Water-based drops hydrate and disintegrate keratin squames; oils lubricate and soften; peroxide releases oxygen that breaks up wax
ENT uses	Impacted or symptomatic wax; before irrigation or microsuction; regular use in patients prone to impaction (hearing aid users)
Dose	Typically 3 to 5 drops two or three times daily for 3 to 5 days
Avoid	Perforated drum or grommet (for most products); otitis externa; arachis and almond oil in nut allergy

2 CHAPTER TWO Using them in ENT

Indications and practice.

2.1 Before removal

NICE advises drops for 3 to 5 days, then irrigation if wax persists (or microsuction in specialist settings). Remove wax only if it causes symptoms, prevents examination or prevents taking an impression for a hearing aid.

2.2 When not to irrigate

Do not irrigate an ear with a perforation or history of one, previous ear surgery, a grommet, a cleft palate repair, acute otitis externa or media, or an only hearing ear, or when the patient has had complications from irrigation before. Use microsuction instead.

2.3 Self-care

Advise patients not to use cotton buds, which push wax deeper; olive oil sprays used regularly reduce impaction.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

Temporary fullness, dizziness or irritation; otitis externa; bubbling and fizzing with peroxide; allergy to nut oils.

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Contraindications to **irrigation**.
- That water-based and oil drops work similarly.
- When wax removal is actually indicated.

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Irrigating an ear with a history of perforation or surgery.
- Arachis oil products in a peanut-allergic patient.

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